

Dear Jen,

I'm sorry that I have not written in the last few days, but nothing much has happened. We are still here at the SCANIA complex just south of the main city of Baghdad. Life is slow and boring. The traffic control points and routine patrols no longer offer any form of excitement. Even the discovery of weapons caches and the nightly explosions signifying their destruction no longer interrupt the steady, monotonous pace. The weapons explosions that shake the buildings and cause the windows to bend almost go unnoticed at this point. I am still working 12 hours a day in the TOC, manning radios but have managed to add some office-type duties to my daily tasking. I am now allowed to type some memos for the commander. Two nights ago, we received our first indications that our Division Command is working on a redeployment plan. The 101st Airborne commander stated in his nightly update that the first units can expect the leave around July 25th. Hopefully we will be among the first to leave—but we just don't know.

When we first arrived in Kuwait, there was a sense of nervous anticipation as we prepared for the inevitable battle with Iraqi forces. With that task completed, we now spend most of our time reading old, outdated magazines searching for any news from home. The highlight of the day, much like it was in Basic Training and OCS, is mail call. Every day, around 4 p.m., mail arrives and is distributed to the different elements of our unit. My shift can be broken down into three distinct parts of the day. When I first come on shift, at 1 pm, all the Field Grade Officers generally mill around the TOC. They ask questions and generally micromanage the operation. It is—by far—the most stressful, annoying part of the day. By 5 pm, however, things tend to settle down. This is when the Brigade Update takes place and the senior officers tend to disappear into their different quarters, and just pop in for a few minutes at a time. We usually spend this time reading magazines or having fly swatting contests (the flies are out of control by the way). Then, finally, by 9 pm everyone has gone to bed. This is when we start our "Worms" Tournaments. Worms is a computer game that someone brought with them. It's a great way to kill time. Everyone in the TOC has their own team based on their rank. For example, one team is the Butter Bars and consists of all the Lieutenants, another is the TOC NCO, which includes all of the Sergeants. As you can imagine, I do pretty well in our little games. Hey, anything to say sane.

Speaking of sanity, it seems to be a tougher and tougher commodity to come by. Now that we have been stationary for over two weeks, I think that we are all starting to go a little stir crazy. Just imagine more than 100 guys in one compound with little to do. Our jobs are no longer new or interesting to any of us, and we have been in each others close company for several months. Tempers and personalities are beginning to clash. Specialist Link might receive the brunt of this. He doesn't seem to understand when to say when. From the minute he comes on duty up until the second he gets off, he runs his mouth. He seems to have a need to prove that he is the smartest or the toughest all of the time, and it doesn't get him anywhere. The other day all of his shit talking got him zip stripped by Sergeant Hodge as if he was an Iraqi POW. I have to admit it was pretty

funny. This is how we do it now. The topic of conversation this morning was led by Sergeant Binda. He was wondering if he could suck his own dick. This led to a quite colorful discussion, really. Before that, he was eating peanuts that had been sent to Lt. Collins. During this event, Sgt. Binda was going on and on about how Lt. Collins' salty nuts tasted so good. The entire discussion came to a "climax," pardon the pun, when I asked him if he spits or swallows.

So that is how it is. The fighting force that is 2-70 Armor reduced to a bunch of bored, underemployed, and extremely ridiculous men. We argue over who gets to read the Maxim, Stuff, or Sports Illustrated Swimsuit Edition magazines that we have floating around, and sneaking in games to kill time. When I get off in the evening, I take two of the 800 mg motrin I scored from the medics in order to sleep well on the hard, stone floor upstairs—plus, at this point, "I'd sniff a bees ass to get a buzz." Otherwise I would like nothing more than to be able to workout. I feel like jello. I get no physical exercise what so ever and you know how I get... Lt. Sproesser does push ups and sit ups at night but I don't want to work up a real sweat since there are no realistic shower facilities. Oh well, I guess I will be puny and soft when I come home.

I miss you and Mason very much and can't wait to come back home. It looks like it will be at least another three months. Anyhow, I am still hoping for a miracle and the chance that it will be sooner.

Love,

A handwritten signature in dark ink, appearing to be the name 'Christian' written in a cursive, stylized script.

Christian